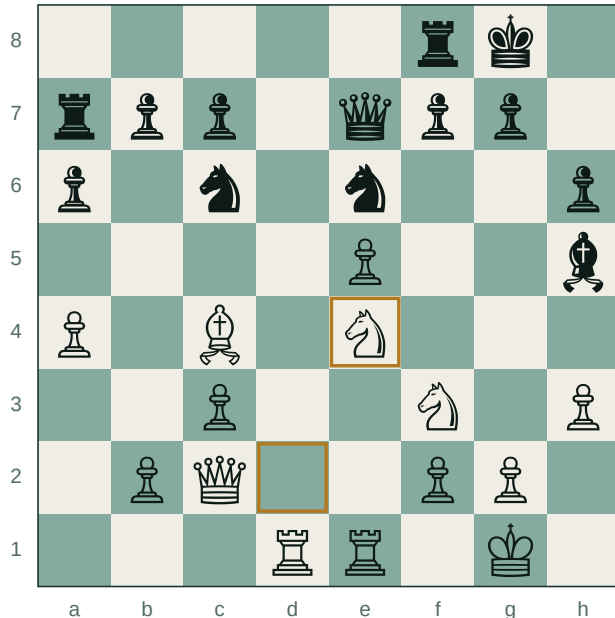


Capture the defender: Black, move 18

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 18.Ne4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

18...Bxf3 19. gxf3 Nxe5

18...Bxf3 The bishop captures the knight on f3. From f3 it attacks rook on d1 and knight on e4. Recorded reply: **19.gxf3**.

19...Nxe5 The knight captures the pawn on e5.

At the end, nominal material is White 31 / Black 31 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1:** the balance goes from -1 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on c4 and queen on c2. Check for tactical protection.